
MINISTRY OF HIGHER EDUCATION
DEPARTMENT OF HIGHER EDUCATION
GENERAL STUDIES SUBJECT (MPU)
MALAYSIA CITRA
TOPIC 2
CULTURAL DIVERSITY:
ETHNICITY & RELIGION
PREPARED BY :
Ms Nursyahida Binti Mohd Jaafar

TOPIC 2

SYNOPSIS

This topic explores Malaysia's cultural diversity through its **major ethnic and religious communities.** It introduces the Malays, Chinese, Indians, Orang Asli, and Indigenous communities of Sabah and Sarawak, together with **selected traditions, customs, and everyday practices** that reflect Malaysia's multicultural society. The topic also examines **religious diversity, cultural sensitivity, social challenges**, and efforts to strengthen **social cohesion** in a diverse society.



TOPIC LEARNING OUTCOMES

Upon completion of this topic, students will be able to:

01 ETHNIC DIVERSITY

Explain the main ethnic groups in Malaysia.



02 RELIGIOUS DIVERSITY

Explore the main religions and beliefs in Malaysia.



03 CULTURAL DIVERSITY AND SOCIAL COHESION

Explain how cultural traditions, mutual respect and social interaction contribute to living together in Malaysia.



How Did Malaysia Become a Multi-Ethnic Society?



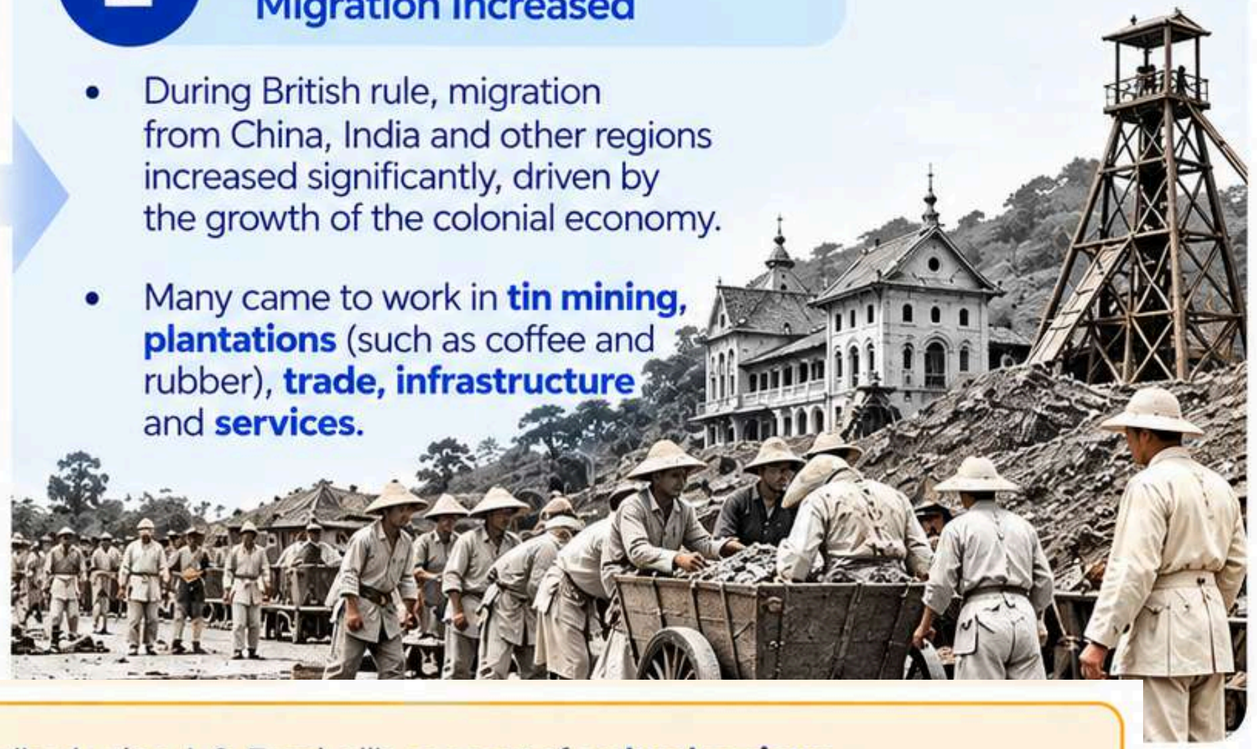
1 BEFORE COLONIAL RULE
Trade & Cultural Exchange

- The Malay Peninsula and Borneo were part of **regional and international maritime trade networks** for centuries.
- By the 15th century, Melaka had developed into a **major trading port (entrepôt)** that attracted merchants from **China, India, Arabia** and other regions.
- Foreign merchants settled permanently, contributing to an early cosmopolitan society with diverse local communities and cultural traditions.



2 COLONIAL PERIOD
Migration Increased

- During British rule, migration from China, India and other regions increased significantly, driven by the growth of the colonial economy.
- Many came to work in **tin mining, plantations** (such as coffee and rubber), **trade, infrastructure** and **services.**



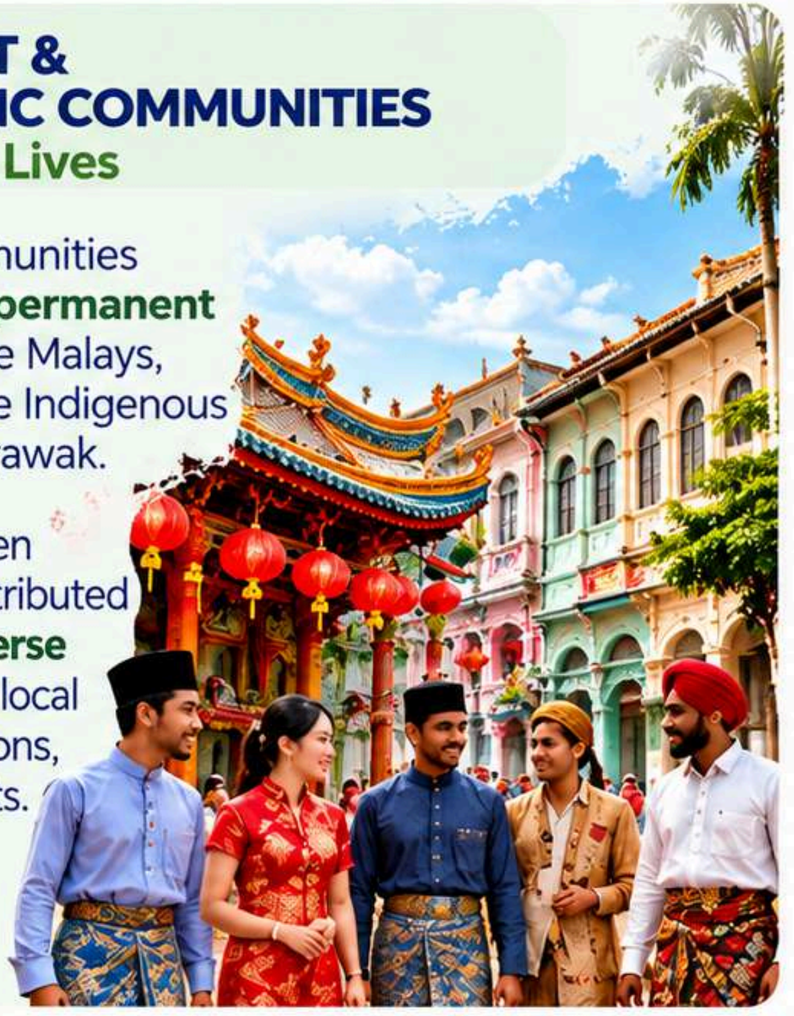
KEY CONCEPT: J. S. FURNIVALL'S "PLURAL SOCIETY" (1948)

Colonial Malaya is often described using J. S. Furnivall's concept of a **plural society:** different ethnic communities living within the same political unit while largely maintaining their own religion, culture, language and social life.

Sources: Furnivall, J. S. (1948). *Colonial Policy and Practice*. Cambridge University Press. | Butcher, J. G. (1979). Towards the History of Malayan Society: Kuala Lumpur District, 1885–1912. *Journal of Southeast Asian Studies*, 10(1), 104–118. | Ariffin, M.et al. (2017). Population and colonial policies in Malaya. *e-Bangi*, 14(3). | Abdul Khalid, R. (2019). Migration and the development of early Malaya. *Jebat*, 46(2).

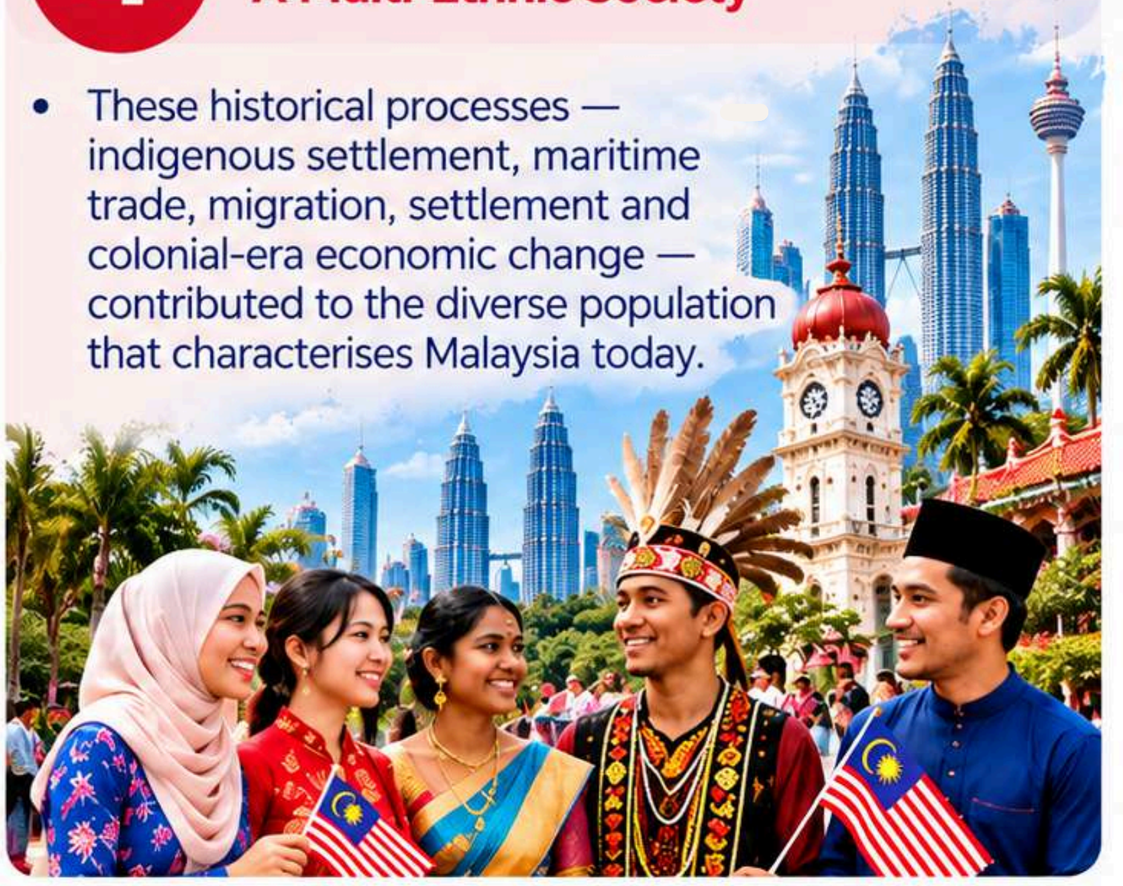
3 SETTLEMENT & MULTI-ETHNIC COMMUNITIES
Building New Lives

- Over time, migrant communities established families and **permanent roots** in Malaya, alongside Malays, Orang Asli and the diverse Indigenous peoples of Sabah and Sarawak.
- Cultural interaction between different communities contributed to Malaysia's **rich and diverse heritage**, including unique local cultures, languages, traditions, food and built environments.



4 MALAYSIA TODAY
A Multi-Ethnic Society

- These historical processes — indigenous settlement, maritime trade, migration, settlement and colonial-era economic change — contributed to the diverse population that characterises Malaysia today.



These diverse communities, with distinct identities, languages and cultural traditions, together form an important part of Malaysia's society.

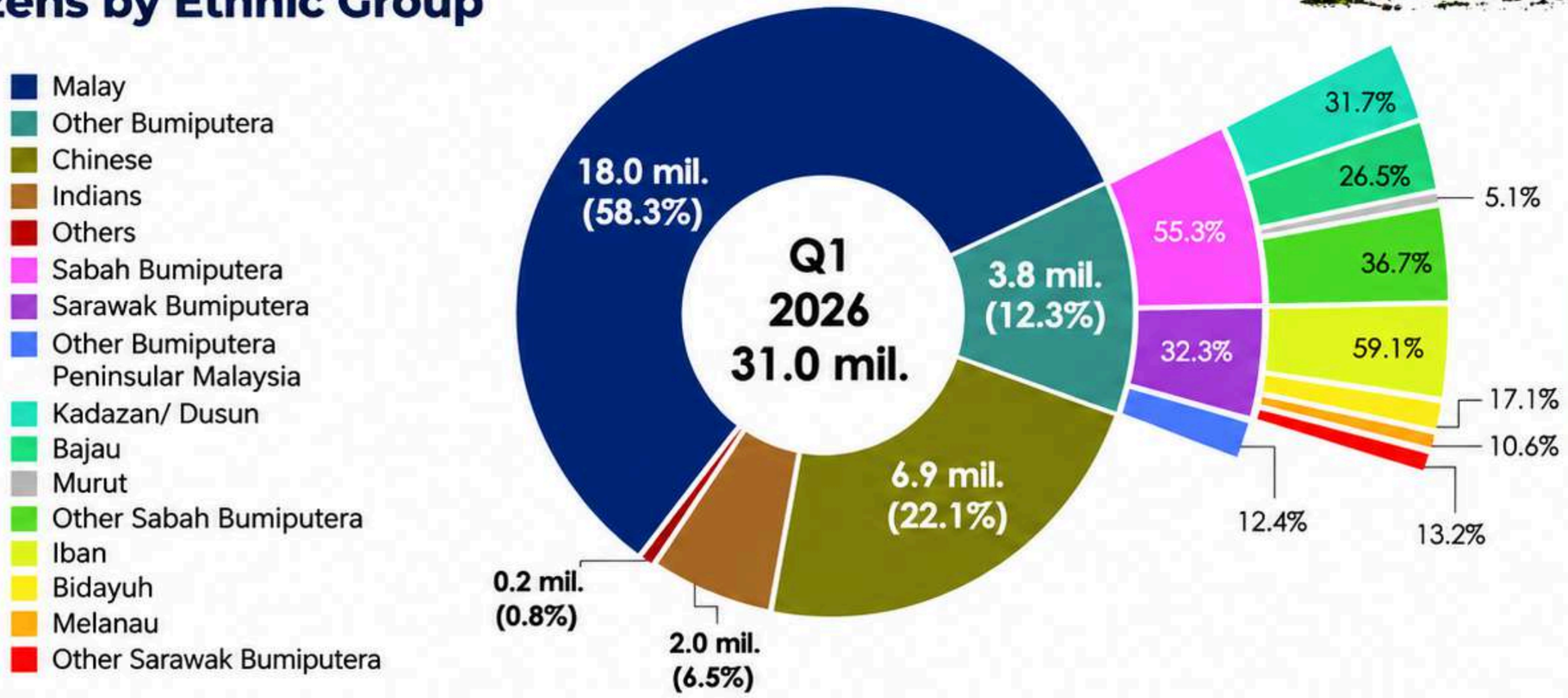
Sources: Department of National Heritage Malaysia, *Sejarah Melayu (The Malay Annals)*; UNESCO World Heritage Centre (Melaka and George Town); Historic Cities of the Straits of Malacca; Department of Statistics Malaysia (DOSM).

Malaysia's Ethnic Composition (Q1 2026)

Latest Release : 14 May 2026



Citizens by Ethnic Group



Total population (2026)
34.4 million
(including non-citizens)

Malaysian citizens (2026)
31.0 million
(90.2% of total population)

Ethnic percentages refer to **Malaysian citizens only,** **not** the total population.

58.3%	12.3%	22.1%	6.5%	0.8%
Malay (18.0 million)	Other Bumiputera (3.8 million)	Chinese (6.9 million)	Indians (2.0 million)	Others (0.2 million)

Source: Demographic Statistics Malaysia, First Quarter 2026, Department of Statistics Malaysia (DOSM).


BUMIPUTERA &
INDIGENOUS COMMUNITIES
A Diverse People, Many Cultures, One Malaysia
Bumiputera is a Malaysian term that broadly refers to the Malays and the indigenous peoples of Malaysia, which include the Orang Asli of Peninsular Malaysia and the indigenous communities of Sabah and Sarawak.

THE MALAY COMMUNITY IN MALAYSIA



The Malays are the indigenous people of the Malay Peninsula and form the **largest ethnic group** in Malaysia.

CONSTITUTIONAL IDENTITY

ARTICLE 160(2)

Under Article 160(2) of the Federal Constitution, a **"Malay"** is a person who:



Professes Islam



Habitually speaks the Malay language



Conforms to Malay custom

Article 160(2) also includes specific conditions relating to birth, descent, and domicile. The three characteristics shown do not constitute the complete constitutional definition of a Malay.

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

- **Early Malay kingdoms**, such as **Kedah** and **Srivijaya**, existed in the region before the rise of the Melaka Sultanate.
- The **Melaka Sultanate** (15th century) became a **major trading centre**, attracting merchants from across Asia and beyond.
- Melaka was also an important centre for the **spread of Islam**, contributing to the development of Malay culture, knowledge and later sultanates in the region.



KEY TAKEAWAY

The Malays have a **long historical presence** in the region and are recognised in the **Federal Constitution**, with a distinct **cultural identity** shaped by **Islam** and **local traditions**.

Sources:

1. Federal Constitution of Malaysia, Article 160(2). (Attorney General's Chambers of Malaysia). https://www.agc.gov.my
2. Department of National Heritage. (n.d.). *The Malay Annals*. https://heritage.gov.my
3. Andaya, L. Y. (2008). *Leaves of the Same Tree: Trade and Ethnicity in the Straits of Melaka*. NUS Press.
4. Khoo Kay Kim. (1977). *The Melaka Sultanate: Internal Administration and Control of Its Empire*. *SEJARAH*, 2(1), 1–20.

CULTURAL IDENTITY & TRADITIONS OF THE MALAYS



1 RELIGION







- **All Malays are Muslims by law,** as defined under Article 160(2) of the Federal Constitution.
- **Islam plays** a **central role** in shaping Malay **cultural identity**, influencing values, way of life, social practices and traditions.
- **Islam continues to guide** Malay culture, language, education and customs in contemporary Malaysia.

2 CUSTOMS AND SOCIAL PRACTICES







- **Marriage ceremonies** are significant social events, often involving specific customs, rituals and family traditions.
- **Family relationships, respect for elders** and strong community ties are important values in Malay society.

3 TRADITIONAL ATTIRE







- **Baju Melayu** (male) and **Baju Kurung** (female) are the commonly worn traditional attire of the Malays.
- **Batik and songket** are also widely used, reflecting local influences and regional styles.
- **Styles, colours and designs** vary by community, region and occasion.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Malay cultural identity reflects a combination of **Islamic values, local customs and traditions** that continue to be an important part of Malaysia's diverse society.

Sources:

- Federal Constitution of Malaysia. **Article 160(2).** (Attorney General's Chambers of Malaysia). https://www.agc.gov.my
- Department of National Heritage. (n.d.). The Malay Annals. https://heritage.gov.my
- Andaya, L. Y. (2008). Leaves of the Same Tree: Trade and Ethnicity in the Straits of Melaka. NUS Press.
- Department of Statistics Malaysia. (2020). Ethnic Composition. https://www.dosm.gov.my



MAJOR CELEBRATIONS

Eid al-Fitr

- Celebrated **after the fasting month of Ramadan.**
- Marked by family gatherings, visiting relatives and seeking forgiveness.
- Common practices include special prayers, festive meals and giving to those in need (e.g. charity or zakat al-Fitr).



Celebrated

Eid al-Adha

- An important Islamic celebration associated with sacrifice, faith and charity.
- Often involves the sharing of meat with family, relatives and those in need.
- Includes special prayers and community activities, such as the distribution of meat to the less fortunate.



TRADITIONAL FOOD AND CUISINE

- Malay cuisine reflects **local ingredients, regional influences** and **cultural traditions.**
- Popular dishes include **nasi lemak**, **rendang**, **satay** and **lemang**, which are enjoyed during everyday meals and special occasions, including festive celebrations.









KEY TAKEAWAY

Malay cultural **identity** reflects a combination of **Islamic values, local customs** and **traditions** that continue to be an important part of Malaysia's diverse society.

Sources:

1. Federal Constitution of Malaysia, Article 160(2). https://www.federalconstitution.gov.my
2. Department of National Heritage. (n.d.). *The Malay Annals*. https://heritage.gov.my
3. Andaya, L. Y. (2008). *Leaves of the Same Tree: Trade and Ethnicity in the Straits of Melaka*. NUS Press.
4. Department of Statistics Malaysia. (2023). *Ethnic Composition*. https://www.dosm.gov.my

ABORIGINES (ORANG ASLI) OF PENINSULAR MALAYSIA

The Orang Asli are the **indigenous peoples** of Peninsular Malaysia. They are one of the **earliest inhabitants** ad the region and have their own unique cultures, languages and ways of life.



Source: Department of Orang Asli Development (JAKOA). (2020). *General Information on the Orang Asli.*

THREE MAIN GROUPS

1 Negrito (northern region)



- Live mainly in the **northern** Peninsular Malaysia (e.g. Perak, Kelantan).
- Generally **smaller in physique** with distinct physical features.
- Some communities traditionally practised hunting, fishing and gathering as part of their livelihoods.
- Include subgroups such as Kintak, Kensiu, Jahai, Bateq and Mendriq.

2 Senoi (central region)



- The **largest group**, living in central Peninsular Malaysia (e.g. Pahang, Perak, Kelantan).
- Traditionally engaged in **swidden agriculture, hunting and gathering.**
- Include subgroups such as Temiar, Semai, Semoq and Jah Hut.

3 Proto-Malay (southern region)



- Live mainly in the **southern** Peninsular Malaysia (e.g. Johor).
- Have **cultural and physical similarities to the Malays.**
- Traditionally engaged in **fishing, hunting and gathering.**
- Include subgroups such as **Jakun**, Temuan, Semelai and Orang Kanaq (Orang Kuala).

KEY TAKEAWAY

The Orang Asli are the **indigenous peoples** of Peninsular Malaysia with **unique cultures, languages and traditions,** and they are an important part of Malaysia's cultural diversity.

Sources:

1. Department of Orang Asli Development (JAKOA). (2020). *General Information on the Orang Asli.* https://www.jakoa.gov.my
2. Smithsonian's National Museum of Natural History. (n.d.). Indigenous Peoples of Malaysia (Orang Asli). https://naturalhistory.si.edu

CUSTOMS AND TRADITIONS OF THE ORANG ASLI



LIVE IN HARMONY WITH NATURE AND THE ENVIRONMENT



- Live in close **harmony with nature** and the **forest**.
- Practise **animism**, believing in spirits that inhabit natural elements such as forests, rivers, mountains and animals.
- Have unique **knowledge of** the **environment**, including plants, animals and traditional medicine.

TRADITIONAL LIVELIHOODS AND SKILLS







- Practise traditional **hunting, fishing** and **gathering**.
- Maintain distinct **cultural practices**, including rituals, storytelling, craft-making and spiritual beliefs.

UNIQUE LIFESTYLE AND KNOWLEDGE





- Their knowledge and sustainable lifestyle reflect a **deep understanding of the natural environment**.
- Some communities continue to practise **traditional hunting, fishing and gathering** as part of their livelihoods.

KEY TAKEAWAY

The Orang Asli have **unique customs, knowledge and traditions** that are closely linked to **nature and their environment**.

Sources:

1. Department of Orang Asli Development (JAKOA). (2020). *General Information on the Orang Asli.* https://www.jakoa.gov.my
2. Smithsonian's National Museum of Natural History. (n.d.). Indigenous Peoples of Malaysia (Orang Asli). https://naturalhistory.si.edu

INDIGENOUS COMMUNITIES OF SARAWAK



Sarawak is home to **diverse Indigenous communities** with distinct customs, traditions and ways of life.

MAIN INDIGENOUS COMMUNITIES

IBAN



- The **largest** Indigenous group in Sarawak.
- Known for their **traditional longhouses** and rich cultural heritage.

BIDAYUH



- One of the main Indigenous communities in Sarawak.
- Known for their traditional **round communal houses (Baruk)** and distinctive customs.

MELANAU



- Traditionally associated with **coastal and riverine communities.**
- Known for the **Kaul Festival**, reflecting their cultural and spiritual heritage.

ORANG ULU



- A collective term for several Indigenous communities, including the Kayan, Kenyah, Kelabit, Lun Bawang, and Penan.
- Different communities have distinctive cultural traditions, including beadwork, woodcarving, and traditional music.

CULTURAL NOTE: GAWAI CELEBRATION

An annual harvest thanksgiving festival celebrated by several Indigenous communities in Sarawak, particularly the **Iban** and **Bidayuh**.



Sources: Sarawak Tourism Board, "Ethnicities of Sarawak"; Amazing Borneo, "People, Culture and Customs"; Amazing Borneo, "What is Gawai Dayak? Sarawak's Harvest Festival and Longhouse Traditions" (2026).

INDIGENOUS COMMUNITIES OF SABAH



Sabah is home to **diverse Indigenous communities** with distinct customs and traditions.

MAIN INDIGENOUS COMMUNITIES

KADAZAN-DUSUN



- The **largest** Indigenous group in Sabah.
- Traditionally associated with **rice cultivation** and celebrate the **Kaamatan (Harvest Festival).**

BAJAU



- Known for their **horse-riding traditions** on the West Coast.
- Have strong **maritime traditions** on the East Coast, with many communities living in coastal areas and on the sea.

MURUT



- Traditionally associated with **inland and riverine areas,** including longhouses.
- Known for their traditional dances, such as the **Magunatip bamboo dance.**

OTHER INDIGENOUS COMMUNITIES



- Include **Rungus, Bisaya, Lun Bawang, Orang Sungai** and other Indigenous groups.
- Each community has its own **distinct customs, languages** and **traditions.**

RELIGIONS AND TRADITIONAL BELIEFS

- Christianity, Islam and traditional Indigenous spiritual beliefs are found across Sabah.
- Religious affiliations and practices **vary between communities and individuals.**

KEY TAKEAWAY

Sabah's Indigenous communities contribute to Malaysia's **rich cultural diversity.**

Sources: 1. Amazing Borneo Tours. People & Culture of Sabah. (n.d.). 2. Amazing Borneo Tours. *Five Indigenous Groups of Mari Mari Cultural Village* (2025, updated 2026).


NON-BUMIPUTERA
COMMUNITIES IN MALAYSIA
Diverse Backgrounds, Shared Future
Non-Bumiputera refers to Malaysians who are not classified as Bumiputera under Malaysia's official ethnic classifications.
They include Malaysian Chinese, Malaysian Indians and other ethnic groups such as Sikhs, Eurasians and Baba Nyonya. They are Malaysian citizens and have the same fundamental rights as all Malaysians, and make significant contributions to Malaysia's history, economy, social development and cultural heritage.

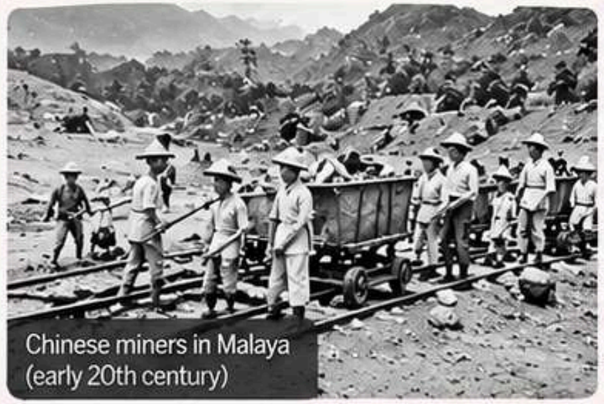
CHINESE COMMUNITY IN MALAYSIA

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

- Chinese merchants traded in Melaka during the **15th-century Melaka Sultanate**, contributing to the region's vibrant trade.
- Larger Chinese migration occurred during the **British colonial period**, particularly for **tin mining and trade.**



Chinese merchants at the port of Melaka (15th century)



Chinese miners in Malaya (early 20th century)



Chinese businesses in colonial Malaya (early 20th century)

CULTURAL IDENTITY

- One of Malaysia's **major ethnic communities.**
- Comprises **diverse heritage groups** such as **Hokkien, Cantonese, Hakka, Teochew and Hainaese,** with different dialects, customs and traditions.
- The **Baba Nyonya (Peranakan Chinese)** represents a distinctive cultural heritage shaped by the blending of Chinese and local Malay influences, especially in Melaka and the Straits Settlements.

DID YOU KNOW?

The Chinese community in Malaysia is culturally diverse, with different heritage groups, customs and traditions.



Hokkien



Cantonese



Hakka



Teochew



Hainanese



Baba Nyonya (Peranakan Chinese)

KEY TAKEAWAY

The Chinese community has a **long historical presence** and is **culturally diverse,** contributing significantly to Malaysia's **economic** and **multicultural development.**

Sources: Tourism Melaka, "Chinese Community"; Department of National Unity and Integration (JPNIN), "Ethnic Groups in Malaysia"; Bank Negara Malaysia Museum, "Keringat – Tales of Our Forefathers".

Chinese New Year

- One of the most **important festivals** for the Chinese community in Malaysia.
- This is a major cultural celebration among Malaysian Chinese communities, marked by family reunions, traditional customs and, for some families, religious practices.



Traditional Attire

- **Cheongsam (qipao)** is a well-known example of **Chinese traditional clothing.**
- Often worn during festivals, weddings and special occasions.





Religious beliefs and practices may overlap and vary among individuals and families.



Buddhism

- Followed by many within the Chinese community.



Taoism

- Also widely practised, often alongside other beliefs.



Christianity

- Practised by a significant number of Chinese Malaysians.



Traditional Chinese Beliefs

- Include ancestor veneration and customary practices that may overlap with Buddhism and Taoism.

KEY TAKEAWAY

The Chinese community maintains its **cultural traditions** and **religious practices** while contributing to Malaysia's **multicultural society.**

Sources: Tourism Melaka, "Chinese Community"; Department of National Unity and Integration (JPNIN), "Ethnic Groups in Malaysia"; Bank Negara Malaysia Museum, "Keringat – Tales of Our Forefathers".

THE INDIAN COMMUNITY IN MALAYSIA



HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

- Indian presence in the Malay world dates back **centuries through trade** and cultural links, particularly with **South India**, including during the **Melaka Sultanate.**
- Larger-scale migration occurred during the **British colonial period**, when many Indians, especially from South India, were brought to Malaya as **plantation** workers, railway workers, clerks and professionals.
- Today, **Malaysian Indians are found across various sectors, including agriculture, plantation, public service, businesses, professionals** and the arts.



ORIGINS AND MIGRATION



Most Malaysian Indians originate from different regions of India, with significant migration from South India during the British colonial period, as well as from North India and other regions.

MAJOR COMMUNITIES

TAMILS



The largest Indian community in Malaysia.

TELUGUS



MALAYALEES



PUNJABIS



GUJARATIS



OTHER INDIAN COMMUNITIES



- North Indians
- Sindhis
- Others

CULTURAL IDENTITY & TRADITIONS OF MALAYSIAN INDIANS



1 RELIGION







- Malaysian Indians practice different religions, including **Hinduism, Sikhism, Christianity, Islam and Buddhism.**
- Religious beliefs and practices vary according to community, family and individual choice.

2 CUSTOMS AND SOCIAL PRACTICES



- **Family relationships, respect for elders** and strong community ties are important in many Malaysian Indian families.
- **Marriage customs and ceremonies** vary across different communities and religious traditions.

3 TRADITIONAL ATTIRE











- **Saree, salwar kameez, veshti** (dhoti) and kurta are common traditional attire.
- Styles, colours and designs vary by community, region and occasion.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Malaysian Indian communities have **diverse religious beliefs, social customs** and **traditional attire,** reflecting their **unique cultural identity** within Malaysia's multicultural society.

Sources:

- Department of National Heritage. (n.d.). Indian community. https://heritage.gov.my
- Andaya, B. W., & Andaya, L. Y. (2017). A history of Malaysia (3rd ed.). Palgrave Macmillan.
- Department of Statistics Malaysia. (2020). Population distribution and basic demographic characteristics. https://www.dosm.gov.my
- Jabatan Warisan Negara. (n.d.). Pakaian tradisional masyarakat India. https://heritage.gov.my

4 MAJOR CELEBRATIONS


Deepavali


Thaipusam


Pongal


Vaisakhi

- **Deepavali** – the festival of lights, celebrated by many Hindus.
- **Thaipusam** – a Hindu festival associated with devotion to Lord Murugan.
- **Pongal** – a Tamil harvest festival expressing gratitude for nature and agricultural abundance.
- **Vaisakhi** – an important Sikh religious festival, also associated with harvest traditions.
- Not all Malaysian Indians celebrate the same festivals, as practices vary by religion and community.

5 TRADITIONAL FOOD AND CUISINE











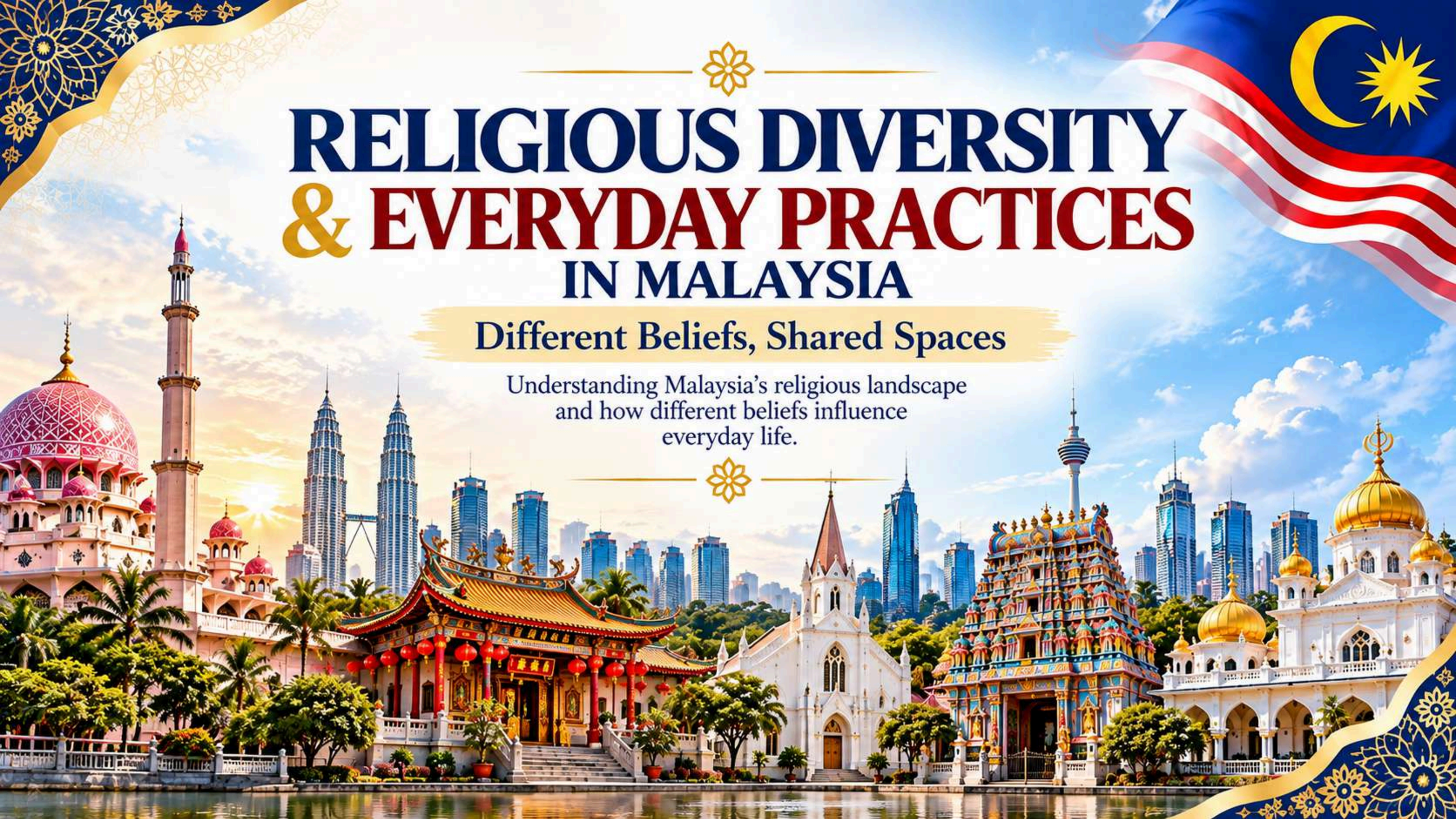
- Malaysian Indian cuisine reflects local ingredients, regional influences and cultural traditions.
- Popular dishes include **roti canai, thosai, idli, banana leaf rice** and **biryani**, among others.
- Food traditions vary by community, region and religious practices.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Malaysian Indian festivals and cuisine reflect the rich **cultural and religious diversity** within the community.

Sources:

- Department of National Heritage. (n.d.). Indian Community. https://heritage.gov.my
- Andaya, B. W., & Andaya, L. Y. (2017). A History of Malaysia (3rd ed.). Palgrave Macmillan.
- Department of Statistics Malaysia. (2020). Population Distribution and Basic Demographic Characteristics. https://www.dosm.gov.my
- Jabatan Warisan Negara. (n.d.). Pakaian tradisional masyarakat India. https://heritage.gov.my


RELIGIOUS DIVERSITY
& EVERYDAY PRACTICES
IN MALAYSIA
Different Beliefs, Shared Spaces
Understanding Malaysia's religious landscape
and how different beliefs influence
everyday life.

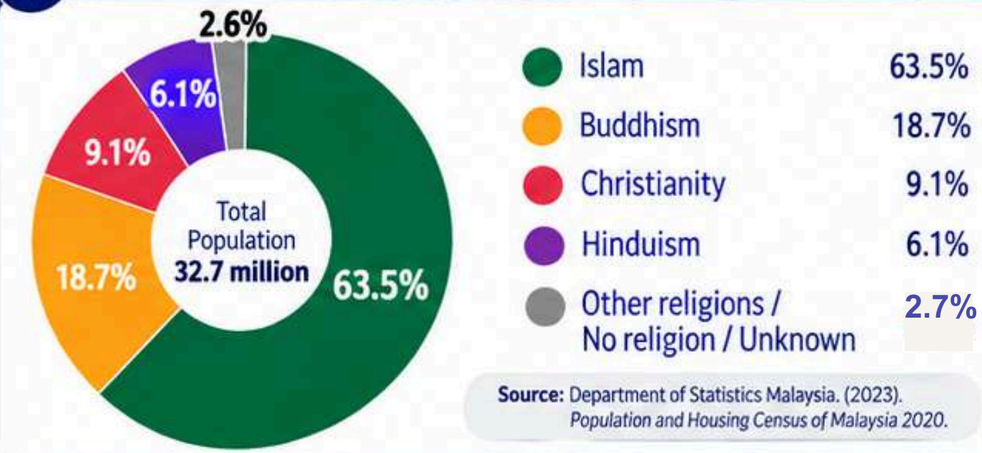
RELIGIOUS DIVERSITY IN MALAYSIA

A Multireligious Society



Article 3(1) establishes Islam as the religion of the Federation while allowing other religions to be practised in peace and harmony. Article 11 provides for freedom of religion, subject to constitutional provisions.

RELIGIOUS COMPOSITION (CENSUS 2020)



Islam	63.5%
Buddhism	18.7%
Christianity	9.1%
Hinduism	6.1%
Other religions / No religion / Unknown	2.7%

Source: Department of Statistics Malaysia. (2023). *Population and Housing Census of Malaysia 2020.*

MAJOR RELIGIONS IN MALAYSIA

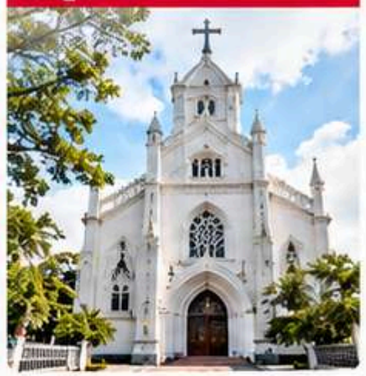
ISLAM



BUDDHISM



CHRISTIANITY



HINDUISM



OTHER RELIGIONS AND BELIEF SYSTEMS IN MALAYSIA

Malaysia's religious landscape is diverse, including a range of other religions and belief systems beyond the four major religions.

SIKHISM



Practised by Malaysian Sikhs. The gurdwara is their place of worship.

TAOISM



Practised by some Malaysian Chinese, often alongside other Chinese traditional beliefs.

CONFUCIAN TRADITIONS



Philosophical and ethical teachings that influence cultural values and practices among some Malaysian Chinese.

INDIGENOUS TRADITIONAL BELIEFS



Diverse ancestral and spiritual traditions practised by some Indigenous communities in Peninsular Malaysia, Sabah and Sarawak.

OTHER RELIGIONS



Include the Bahá'í Faith and other smaller religious communities.

Sources:

1. Department of Statistics Malaysia (DOSM). (2022). Key Findings: Population and Housing Census of Malaysia 2020.
2. Federal Constitution of Malaysia. Article 3 and Article 11.

RELIGIOUS DIETARY PRACTICES IN MALAYSIA

Food Choices Shaped by Beliefs



ISLAM



Halal (Permissible)

- Food and drinks that are permitted under Islamic dietary laws.
- Meat must come from permissible animals and be slaughtered according to Islamic requirements (halal slaughter).

Non-Halal (Not Permissible)

- Includes pork, alcoholic beverages and meat that does not meet Islamic dietary requirements.

Important

- Halal is not simply about avoiding pork. Food ingredients, preparation, handling and storage also need to follow Islamic rules.

HINDUISM







- Many Hindus **avoid beef** because cows are regarded as sacred.
- Some Hindus **practise vegetarianism,** while others consume meat (except beef).
- Dietary practices may **vary according to region, community and individual beliefs.**

KEY TAKEAWAY

Understanding and respecting different dietary practices helps Malaysians from diverse religious backgrounds share meals and social spaces comfortably.

Sources: 1. Department of Islamic Development Malaysia (JAKIM). (n.d.). Halal Malaysia. https://www.islam.gov.my 2. Department of Statistics Malaysia, (2023). Population and Housing Census of Malaysia 2020.



BUDDHISM







- Some Buddhists practise **vegetarianism** as an expression of compassion and non-harming towards all living beings.
- Some Buddhists avoid meat, while others may consume meat depending on their tradition and individual practice.
- Vegetarian practices **vary among Buddhist traditions and individuals.**

SIKHISM











- **Sikh** dietary practices vary. The Sikh code of conduct prohibits ritually slaughtered meat, while some Sikhs follow vegetarian diets.
- **Christians** generally do not have specific dietary restrictions, although some may observe fasting or abstinence during certain periods (e.g. Lent).
- **Other religious communities,** such as certain Indigenous groups, may follow their own customary dietary practices.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Dietary practices in Malaysia are shaped by **diverse religious beliefs,** and they reflect the **values, traditions** and **lifestyles** of each community.

Sources:

1. Department of Islamic Development Malaysia (JAKIM). (n.d.). Halal Malaysia. https://www.islam.gov.my
2. Department of Statistics Malaysia. (2021). Hindu, Buddhist, and Housing Census of Malaysia 2020.
3. Various academic and religious sources on Hindu, Buddhist, Sikh and Christian dietary practices.

EVERYDAY EXAMPLES OF CULTURAL & RELIGIOUS PRACTICES IN MALAYSIA

These practices are part of daily life in Malaysia and reflect the country's diverse cultural and religious traditions.

1 DRESS APPROPRIATELY

- Wear **modest and appropriate clothing** when visiting religious sites such as mosques, temples, churches or other places of worship.
- Some places may **provide covering** (e.g. shawls or sarongs) if needed.
- **Dress respectfully** when visiting government offices like a more formal or conservative attire (e.g. long sleeves, long pants or skirts).



2 RESPECT PLACES OF WORSHIP

- **Be mindful of rules** (e.g. remove shoes, maintain quiet behaviour, respect sacred areas).
- Take **photographs only when permitted**.
- **Follow dress codes** and any guidelines set by the place of worship.





3 GREETING

- Malaysians have **different ways of greeting**, such as handshakes, verbal greetings or a slight bow, according to cultural norms.
- Some may prefer **not to have physical contact** due to religious or cultural reasons.
- It is polite to **greet with a smile**, **show respect** and follow the lead of others.







4 FESTIVES PRACTICES AND INVITATION

- Different communities observe **different religious and cultural celebrations.**
- When attending celebrations, **be respectful** of the host's customs and follow any guidance provided.
- Be **open to learning** about different traditions and practices.









IMPORTANT NOTE

- Practices may vary between communities, families and individuals.
- Not everyone within the same ethnic or religious group follows the same practices.
- When in doubt, always ask politely and be respectful.
- These practices are part of Malaysia's cultural diversity and contribute to a more inclusive and harmonious society.

Sources:

1. Department of National Unity and Integration (JPNIN). (2021). Guidelines on Interfaith Relations in Malaysia.
2. Tourism Malaysia, (n.d.). Etiquette and Dress Code at Religious Sites in Malaysia. https://www.malaysia.travel
3. Jabatan Perpaduan Negara. (2023). Garis Panduan Etika Beragama di Malaysia.
4. Department of Islamic Development Malaysia (JAKIM). (n.d.). General Guidelines for Visitors at Mosques.
5. Ministry of Tourism, Arts and Culture Malaysia. (n.d.). Malaysian Greetings and Cultural Etiquette.
6. Department of Statistics Malaysia. (2022). Population and Housing Census of Malaysia 2020 – Ethnic and Religious Composition.

CHALLENGES OF LIVING IN A DIVERSE SOCIETY



1 STEREOTYPES & PREJUDICE



Judging people based on assumptions about their ethnicity, culture or religion.

2 CULTURAL & RELIGIOUS MISUNDERSTANDINGS



Limited understanding of different beliefs and customs may cause tension.

3 LANGUAGE & COMMUNICATION BARRIERS



Language differences can make communication and mutual understanding difficult.

4 SOCIAL SEPARATION



Limited interaction between communities can weaken trust and relationships.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Diversity becomes a strength when differences are understood and respected.

Sources:
1. Ministry of National Unity. (2021). National Unity Policy (Dasar Perpaduan Negara).
2. UNESCO. (2009). UNESCO World Report: Investing in Cultural Diversity and Intercultural Dialogue.

MANAGING DIVERSITY IN MALAYSIA

Building a Harmonious and Inclusive Society



1 NATIONAL PRINCIPLES AND VALUES

Principles such as Rukun Negara guide Malaysians to live together based on mutual respect, tolerance and unity.

- Belief in God
- Loyalty to King and Country
- Upholding the Constitution
- Rule of Law
- Good Behaviour and Morality



2 POLICIES AND INITIATIVES

The government implements various policies and programmes to promote national unity, social integration and equal opportunities for all communities.

- National Unity Policy
- Education and community
- programmes
- Economic development
- Inclusive policies for all Malaysians



KEY TAKEAWAY

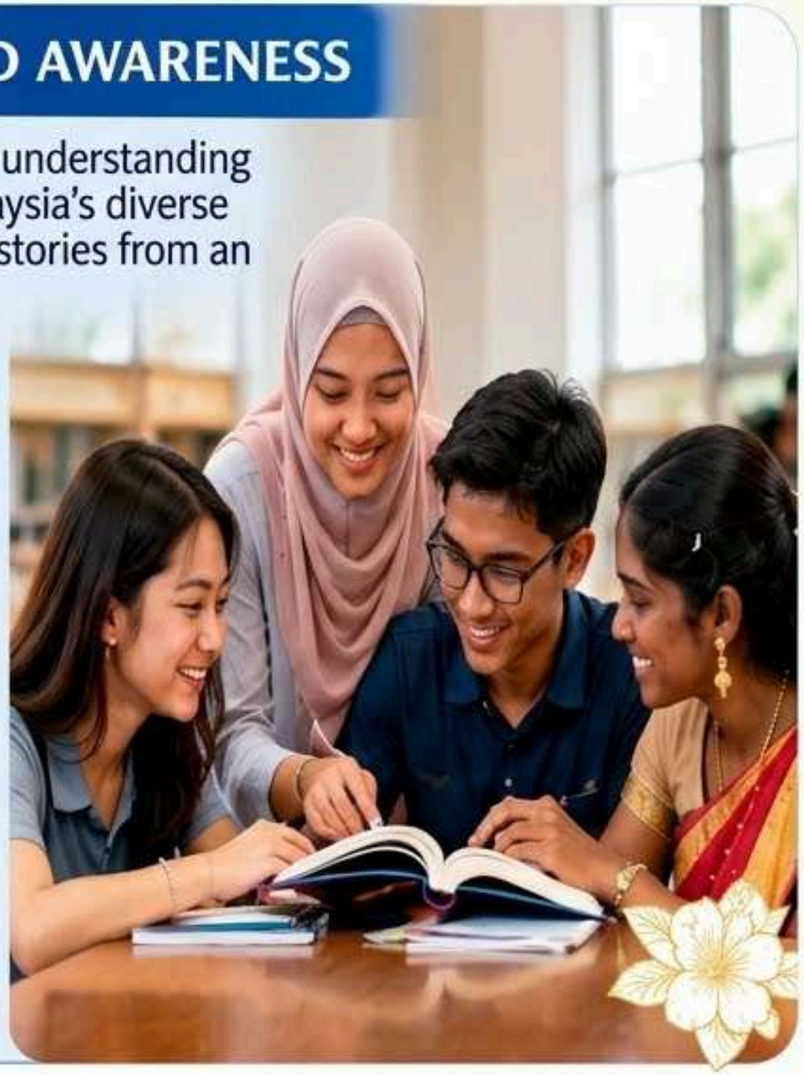
National principles and government initiatives provide a common foundation for a united and inclusive Malaysia.

Sources:
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2. Department of National Unity. (n.d.). Rukun Negara.

3 EDUCATION AND AWARENESS

Education helps to build understanding and appreciation of Malaysia's diverse cultures, religions and histories from an early age.

- Multicultural education in schools and universities
- Intercultural dialogue and activities
- Learning about each other's cultures



4 COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT AND INTERACTION

Interactions through community activities, festivals, sports and volunteer work help build trust, friendships and a stronger sense of national identity.

- Inter-ethnic and inter-religious activities
- Community service and volunteerism festivals
- Sports and youth programmes

- Festivals, sports and volunteersm
- Sports and
- youth youth programmes



KEY TAKEAWAY

Education and community engagement create meaningful interactions and strengthen mutual understanding in a diverse society.

Sources: 1. Ministry of Education Malaysia. (2013). Malaysia Education Blueprint 2013–2025.
2. Ministry of National Unity. (2021). National Unity Policy (Dasar Perpaduan Negara).

CONCLUSION

“Different Cultures, Shared Society”

A Multicultural Society
Malaysia is home to diverse ethnic communities, religions, traditions, and cultural identities.

Respecting Differences
Understanding different beliefs, customs, and practices encourages mutual respect and reduces misunderstandings.

Living Together
Despite cultural and religious differences, Malaysians share public spaces, everyday experiences and a common national identity.

Building a United Malaysia
Social cohesion requires continuous efforts through education, mutual understanding, inclusive policies and meaningful interactions.



KEY TAKEAWAY

Malaysia’s cultural diversity is a **strength.** By understanding, respecting and preserving our different cultures and traditions, we can continue to build a **harmonious and inclusive society.**

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